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‘Make way for MTC buses to enter Arunachalam Road’



Construction debris under the Metro rail pillar at Arunachalam Road intersection and (below) MTC buses taking a turn near Mosque Garden First Street intersection. PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B.

M.R. VASUDEVAN

Construction materials, debris and a broken median under the metro rail pillar near the junction of Arcot Road and Arunachalam Road in Saligramam need to be cleared.

The exact spot is near HP Petrol bunk.

This prevents MTC buses from

entering Arunachalam Road from Arcot Road.

The affected bus services are: 17E (Royapuram - Saligramam) and 12B (Pattinapakkam - Saligramam) on their trip to Saligramam.

For the past few years, these buses were diverted through P.T. Rajan Salai in K.K. Nagar due to Metro rail work on the Vadapalani section of Arcot Road. Since July, this

original route has been restored.

However, due to this block under the pillar at the junction, these buses take a turn near the intersection of Mosque Garden First Street which is a few metres away. Chennai Metro Rail Limited and Metropolitan Transport Corporation should do the needful.

M.R. Vasudevan is a resident of Saligramam

Saidapet court bus stop ‘ignored’

SABEENA

What was the point of moving the traffic signal at Little Mount by a few metres away and installing it at the junction of LDG Road,

blocking entry/exit while MTC buses stop right at the junction and not at the bus stop. MTC ignores discipline and Greater Chennai Traffic Police ignores enforcement. A new bus stop has

been inaugurated near Saidapet court but MTC. But the crew have not been instructed to stop at the designated bus stop and not at the signal. In short, a traffic signal and a bus stop all at one junction.

Sabeena is a resident of Sringeri Colony, Saidapet

‘Electricity transformer near school needs to be fenced’



SUMATHI SRIDHAR

The electricity transformer at Bharatiyar Street in Saligramam needs to be fenced. It is located along the compound wall of Kaveri school. The area under the transformer is being misused to dump waste. A spark can cause a major fire accident. Cables and electricity boxes also occupy the space in the street. They are lying here for the past few months. Also, a mechanic shop extends its work area to the road. Several complaints to Greater Chennai Corporation have been in vain.

Sumathi Sridhar is a resident of Saligramam



Bharatiyar Street in Saligramam. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

8th Avenue in Harrington Road needs new transformer

SUDHA UMASHANKER

Residents of 8th Avenue (Tara-pore Avenue) off Harrington Road have for long suffered frequent power disruptions and were told that the cause was the overload due to excessive use of air-conditioners. Loud explosions would occur when this happened. An appeal to provide a new trans-

former is pending. Of the two distribution boxes that are serving the area now, one is in a bad shape, open and exposed to rain. This needs to be attended to without delay. Senior citizens who use medical equipment and those who work from home are badly affected by erratic power supply.

Sudha Umashanker is a resident of Tarapore Avenue, Harrington Road, Chetpet

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Lift out of order at Virugambakkam sub registrar office



For the past one year, the lift at the Sub Registrar Office in Virugambakkam on Arcot Road is not functioning. Visitors need to climb a steep and narrow staircase. Besides, the surface of approach path to the office is uneven. Further, visitors have to meander their way through parked vehicles at the entrance. All these make it quite difficult for senior citizens. It may be noted that in May 2022, the State Government made a decision that sub-registrar offices across the State would be shifted to the ground floor and the ones not functioning from the ground floor would be provided with lift facility. This decision was made for the benefit of senior citizens and the differently abled. The authorities concerned should restore the lift at the earliest. Besides, the authorities should consider shifting this office to another location as space is a constraint here. PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B



LIFY THOMAS

Parents carry vegetable peels to school in Saidapet

Students of Fathima Central Senior Secondary School are given hands-on training in sustainability

Since the new academic year commenced this year at Fathima Central Senior Secondary School, Deepa B., a mother of two, has been following a practice diligently. She has all the vegetable peels from her kitchen dried at the terrace of her home, wraps them in a newspaper to be taken to the school every Saturday where she drops them in a vermicomposter.

Many parents at this school affiliated to Central Board of Secondary Education are nudged by the school management to bring their vegetable waste for composting on the school premises. And Saturday is set aside for this exercise. Currently, students of classes IX and XI follow the cycle for three months, after which it is the turn of students of classes V to VIII.

Some parents drop the waste mid-week as they do not want it to accumulate at home. And those like Deepa, who has children studying in classes VII and IX, dry it so that it is free of insects. "The quantity of wet waste that I send out is minimal, and seeing me my neighbour has also started sending it to the school's composter," says Deepa, appreciating the school for giving students a hands-on lesson in sustainability and science.

Fathima Central Senior Second-

dary School does not boast an expansive campus (it is less than an acre) but has taken a slew of initiatives to set an example for students and the community around that every small action makes a difference.

Shalika Banu, the vice-principal who has been driving such environment-friendly initiatives at the school, says the composting initiative has been running on the campus since 2015. Composting was earlier done in cement tanks but they discontinued the process three years ago to switch to the vermicomposting method. Even during the pandemic the school did not take a break as gardener Mani took care of it. Now, he is supported by Selvi. Currently, the campus has five vermicompost bins where dried cow dung and shredded coir are added to accelerate the process.

As regular supply of compost is ensured, the management went a



Students of Fathima Central Higher Secondary School in Saidapet.

step ahead to launch its own brand by the name "CONEURE" sold to the parents and the community around. Close to 25 kilos of nutrient-rich compost is generated once in three months.

The school has a 'Smart Water Irrigation System', and 15-litre cans

are used to grow vegetables such as tomatoes and chilli. As part of work education, students play a key role in maintaining the garden. Teachers have been promoting the growing of micro greens among the parent community for its nutritional benefits.

Shalika, who has been associated with the school for the last 19 years. "I had attended a teacher orientation workshop by R. Kishore Kumar of St John's Schools who motivated me with his talk on who is a great teacher. I had shared that with my 2013 batch who were keen on starting something that benefits society and that set the ball rolling," says Shalika, who recently won the Vidhya Seva Samman award for the 'Best Teacher'.

Starting an eco-friendly team and the Green Clean Illuminators Club were the early initiatives taken at the school.

"We made paper bags and distributed them to those waiting at the Nandanam signal. In another initiative, we gave away saplings that we received after a 'plant growing competition'," she recalls.

The award-winning teacher says in all these initiatives they ensure 'no student is left behind' as every project is linked to subjects such as Science, Mathematics, History and English and parents are happy to support the learning process.

Shalika is thankful for the support she received from both director Nigar Akthar and principal Naaz Parwar. "I would not have been able to cover so much ground without them giving me a free hand," she adds.

Taking a shot at a rare avocation

Dealers of airguns in Chennai note that enthusiasts of recreational airgun target shooting are on the rise

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

A sharp crack followed by a silence probably lasting just a picosecond and therefore going unregistered, and then the loud pop of a balloon bursting from a pellet shot. Those sounds, in that sequence, are heard every day at Marina and Bessie. And usually, to create that sequence of sounds ten times on the trot, with the hire of an air rifle and a balloon target screen, a beach-goer would have to part with ₹50. There are those who seek to make this one-time indulgence a regular habit not by visiting the beach every day, but by a one-time visit to a shop selling airguns.

Welcome to the hobby of recreational airgun shooting which can be practised in a controlled environment at one's own private space. At Asian Air Guns on Perambur Barracks Road, Ashwin Kumar underlines that owning an airgun does not entail getting a license by meeting a fusillade of requirements. That said, there are still requirements to be met. One, the buyer has to be at least 18 years of age and offer proof of identity by presenting a copy of their Aadhar card or driving license. "Aadhar card is preferred," he emphasises.

Another requirement, something that cannot be met by the presentation of a photocopied document, is responsible behaviour. There is discretion to be followed while carrying an air rifle or air pistol. Brandish it in public, and you would find yourself on the wrong side of the law, the act being counted as a punishable offence. While being transported, the airgun has to be carried in a case, covered and hidden from

the public, Ashwin explains.

"When we sell an airgun, irrespective of the price at which it is sold, we take a primer on how to use it, which includes how to use it responsibly. We cannot expect everyone to know the dos and don'ts of it and hence the time, 30 to 45 minutes, we spend educating them," says Ashwin, adding that airgun literacy is indispensable given that target shooting enthusiasts are on the increase. A good number of them take up target shooting away from the glare of the sporting arena because of the quiet benefits it brings to the mind: focus and stress-busting rejuvenation. But an equally good number of them would be cutting their shooting tooth on airguns with the objective of eventually graduating to professional shooting, which involves get-

ting a license. Ashwin likens it to learning to ride a basic scooter before entering a bike race, "If you want to become a bike racer you first learn to ride an Activa."

Besides the logical learning process, there is also economy involved in taking it step by step. He elaborates: "Joining a shooting club and taking up advanced training would automatically lead someone to invest heavily in costly equipment. And what if someone discovers shooting is not their thing after making that investment? Airguns is a

cost-effective way for someone to find out whether shooting is for them or not." And even with an air pistol and air rifle, one could enter a competitive fray, nationally and internationally, as a category with 10M air rifle for men and women and air pistol for men and women exists.

Ashwin brings this perspective to table as he has been on the other side of the counter as well, as a buyer of shooting equipment for his own use, being a licensed shooter and a member of Chennai Rifle Club. In fact, he shares a passion

for shooting with his father S. Ramesh Balaji who established Asian Air Guns in 2005. Both father and son have made a comeback to the shooting range, the former after a 25-year hiatus and the latter, a 10-year break. But as for their business, they want to stick to selling just airguns.

Anna City Armoury also has a history etched with father-son teamwork. Located on Raja Muthiah Road in Periamet, the shop was started in 1993 by T. Selvamani, who had earlier worked with P. Orr & Sons. The "Armoury" in the enterprise's name signifies continuity in Selvamani's professional life. P. Orr & Sons had a link with the armoury business before being associated entirely with horology. The last embers of its identity as a manufacturer and seller of firearms were smouldering in 1967.

Anna City Armoury is run by Selvamani's son, S. Sivabalan, 49, who joined his father while pursuing his degree, and would go on to take over the business entirely after his father's demise in 2015. The shop deals in airguns as well as firearms that require license on the part of the buyer as well as the dealer. Sivabalan admits that the latter, that is selling airguns is the easier proposition. But that is not without its challenges either: one of them is that helped by technology, manufacturers sell directly to consumers with the result that the middle ground occupied by dealers has narrowed.

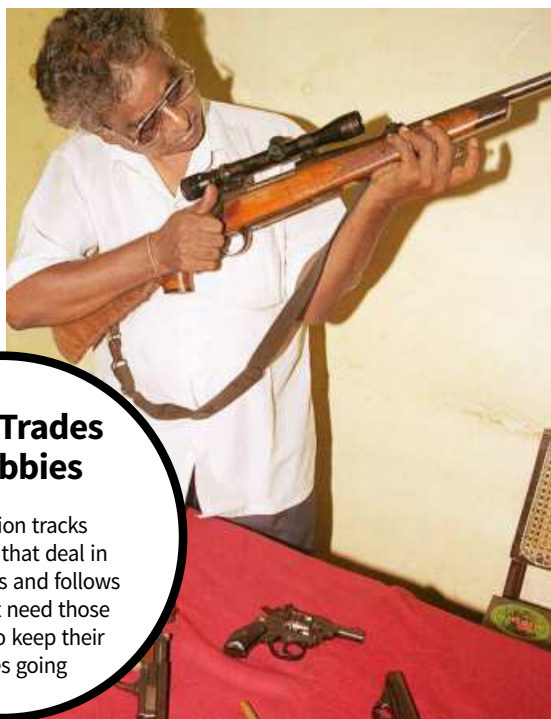


Airguns on display; airguns at a balloon popping shop in Marina; T. Selvamani founder of Anna City Armoury at Periamet; and Ashwin Kumar of Asian Air Guns at Perambur Barracks Road.



Niche Trades & Hobbies

This section tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going



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Chennai's little Krishnas and Radhas steal the limelight

More than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu participated in this edition of *The Hindu Downtown Maya Kannan*

Maya Kannan 2026 authored by *The Hindu Downtown* concluded on a joyous note with the grand prize distribution ceremony held at Gyan Bhawan Auditorium in AM Jain College, Meenambakkam on September 13.

The contest received an overwhelming response with the participation of more than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu. As part of the Chennai edition which covers the KTCC districts, the contest was organised across five *Downtown* zones, with 13 winners selected from each zone, taking the total number of winners to 65.

The winners were shortlisted after careful evaluation by the jury, with performance, creativity and overall presentation being key considerations. The presence of several children dressed as little Krishna and Radha added a special charm to the occasion, making the selection process particularly challenging for the jury.

After the winners were finalised, they were invited to the prize distribution ceremony along with their parents and families.

The event became an opportunity not only to recognise the young winners but also to celebrate the encouragement and support provided by their families.

The programme began on a graceful note with captivating classical music and dance performances by the talented students of AM Jain School. Their well-presented performanc-

es added a cultural touch to the celebration and were thoroughly enjoyed and appreciated by everyone present. The guests who participated in the inauguration are: P. Suresh Chand Chordia, management committee member, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions, Gayathri, general manager, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions; Vinod Balaji, managing director, Narpavi; S. Ramalingam; insurance advisor and mutual fund distributor; Balaji, store manager, Poorvika Appliances.

The sponsors: The title partner

for the event was Gopuram Turmeric Powder & Kumkum, co presented by Dheepam Lamp Oil, Poorvika Appliances. Associate Partners for the event were Narpavi, S.Ramalingam, Insurance Advisor and Mutual fund Distributor and T.T. Asafoetida. The food partner was Cafe Coffee House, the venue partner was A.M.Jain College. Meenambakkam, Chennai, and the water partner was Repute Water. Gifts were sponsored by Hirlaptop.com. DIFA, Naga food products, P S Tamarind, RAS Chekku Oil, Vivekanandha Sarees and Priyadarshini Cell Universe.

From the event held at AM Jain College in Meenambakkam on September 13. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Winners of T Nagar Zone



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VARUN KRISHNAN



MAKSHITA . B

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A.M. DHANANYAA



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

At SSM Nagar in Alapakkam, New Perungalathur, residents have been having an extended Ganesh Chaturthi for the last three years, making the clay Ganeshas central to a recycling initiative. As in the previous two years, under an in-house initiative, 'KAA-TRU' (Keeping Awareness And Action Towards Recycling and Upcycling), helmed by P.S. Jayaraman, has collected clay Ganeshas and kept them ready for potters.

Residents are asked to choose natural, unpainted clay idols and, after the celebrations, leave them at a designated collection point near the Pillayar Kovil. From there, the idols are handed over to potters.

P.S. Jayaraman, a resident of SSM Nagar, initiated this exercise three years ago inspired by a newspaper article about how Malini Kalyanam, pottery artist and environmentalist. "She was in Teynampet. There was a newspaper article saying that Ganesha idols need not be put into water and cause pollution, and that they could instead be given back to potters," he says. The article prompted Jayaraman to contact Malini, after which the community arranged for its idols to be collected and sent to potters.

The arrangement changed in the second year, when Jayaraman began looking for potters who could directly collect them from the community. "I looked on Google and contacted four or five potters inside Chennai," he says. Eventually, a potter near Kovalam connected him with another potter in Mahabalipuram, who agreed to collect the idols and reuse the material. "From the second year onwards, we started

An extended and green Ganesh Chaturthi

An initiative to recycle clay Ganeshas started by Teynampet resident Malini Kalyanam has impacted many resident groups in Chennai and beyond. Under the aegis of The PALM, headquartered in Tiruvallur, the 'Beautiful Bharat — Save Clay' drive has found volunteer groups across Tamil Nadu



Clay Ganeshas collected at SSM Nagar. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sending the idols directly to him. Last time, we sent around 900 to 1,000 Ganeshas," Jayaraman says.

This year, around 200 to 250 idols had already been collected, with residents expected to continue bringing them in until the afternoon of September 19. Jayaraman has also been urging residents to think about their choices before the festival. The campaign asks them to avoid Plaster of Paris idols, non-eco-friendly paints and decorations. "I have been telling them not

to buy painted Ganeshas or plaster Ganeshas," he says.

For Malini Kalyanam, who is Director of the Artistic Pottery Training Academy in Kattupakkam and one of the founders of The PALM, a public charitable trust, the issue goes beyond what happens to an idol after the festival. As a pottery artist, she has also watched the availability of natural clay decline. This year, her academy received enquiries from corporates as well as members of the public looking to purchase clay for Chaturthi work-

shops, only to find it difficult to source.

"This year we had enqui-

ries from corporates and the public alike to purchase clay for Chaturthi workshops, and that is when they said it is not available online or even at shops in the locality. This shows that demand is high but supply is on the lower side," she says. Malini says the recycling project has been around for nearly a decade, but awareness has picked up considerably in recent years. With more people asking what they should do with their idols after the festival, the initiative has gradually expanded into a larger conversation about responsible celebration.

Malini, a Teynampet resident who has shifted her base to Tiruvallur for running The PALM, notes that the clay Ganesha idols recycling initiative, titled "Beautiful Bharath — Save Clay" powered by The PALM, has grown bigger, being pan-Tamil Nadu now as volunteers from across the state, which

includes P.S. Jayaraman of SSM Nagar, are chipping in. Malini notes plans are afoot to extend the initiative to cities such as Mumbai and Hyderabad.

An alternative application

Malini Kalyanam notes that if a collection facility or a potter is not available, the clay from the Ganesha idols can be used in tree-planting exercises. She suggests placing the idol in a bucket of water and letting it break down over a few days. Once the clay settles into a powder, it can be reused. However, Malini says, the clay should not simply be poured around a plant or sapling and expected to act as element of nourishment. For it to support plant growth, it needs to be mixed with other materials. She lists the ingredients that mixed with the clay that has dried up as a powder and found impressive results: garden soil, compost, perlite or sand, mushroom molasses and water. The ratio of the ingredients would depend on the sapling, she notes.

DAC launches luxury residences

DAC Developers, one of the city's leading construction companies, recently launched an ultra-luxury residential apartment project, Balmandaisa, on St. Thomas Mount-Poonamallee Road.

At the launch, the company held a logo-revealing ceremony at its Balmandaisa office.

The residential project offers expansive residences, premium amenities and strategic connectivity. It has 194 residences, offering two-and three-bedroom apartments and four-and five-bedroom duplex residences. The residences are complemented by a standalone ground-plus-three-floor clubhouse spanning 10,000 square feet, said a

release.

The project comprises two basement levels, stilt, and 13 residential floors, creating a well-integrated residential community.

The homes are priced from ₹1.19 crore, added the release.

Sathish Kumar Santhanam, founder and managing director, DAC Developers; Kumar Vembu, founder, Mudhal Partners Private Limited and co-founder, Zoho; Hari Vignesh R, senior relationship manager, construction finance; Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, and Manjunath Selvamani, regional sales manager, Prime Home Loans, Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, took part.

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